

Reading Walls and Ceilings

How to look, and what each kind of crack or mark is actually telling you.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 3 TIMES

A flashlight can be used during wall inspections to:

Shine parallel to the wall to look for irregularities.

Light held flat against the surface rakes across it, so every bulge, hollow and taped joint throws a shadow. Pointed straight at the wall the same light flattens everything and shows nothing. This is a technique question, and the word that matters is parallel.

What each defect means

Bulging interior walls	Indicate a problem with the studs.
Thin cracks at the exterior corner of a gypsum plaster wall	Likely caused by too thin an application of plaster.
Dark lines showing through paint at sheetrock joints	Indicate the joint compound was damp when painted.
Nail pop	The protrusion of a nail from a wall or ceiling, as framing shrinks and moves behind the board.
Shadowing	An undesirable condition where the joint finish shows through the surface decoration.

The numbers here

Plaster crack suggesting an underlying structural problem

1/2 in wide

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 2 TIMES

Cracks found in a plaster wall may indicate an underlying structural problem if they are:

One-half inch wide.

Below a half inch a plaster crack is ordinary shrinkage and movement. Half an inch is the width at which you stop describing and start recommending evaluation.

Humidity, and what is not a clue

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All of the following are clues that excess humidity may be a problem in the house EXCEPT:

Excessive drafts.

Condensation on windows, musty smells, staining and mold all say there is too much moisture. Drafts say the opposite — air moving through a house carries moisture out of it. On an EXCEPT question, find the option pointing the other way.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 2 TIMES

Which of the following is not an issue in the attic inspection?

Drainage.

In an attic you are looking at insulation, ventilation, framing, wiring and evidence of leaks. Drainage is a site and roof-surface concern; there is nothing to drain inside an attic.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. How do you hold a flashlight to inspect a wall, and why?
2. Bulging walls point to what?
3. Thin cracks at a plastered corner, and dark lines at sheetrock joints — causes?
4. At what width does a plaster crack suggest a structural problem?
5. Name three clues of excess humidity, and the one that is not.
6. Which of the usual concerns is not an attic issue?